

SECTION FOUR

ECONOMY, LABOUR & RESOURCES

Money makes the world go round, even fantasy worlds. Economics determines who eats and who starves, who has power and who serves, who gets to choose their life and who never had a choice to begin with. It shapes what people do all day, what they aspire to, and what they're willing to sacrifice. And in romantasy, economics is the invisible force that tilts every relationship before it even begins.

The Invisible Ledger Principle

Every relationship contains a ledger. Not literally - no one writes down each tally in a notebook (usually.) However, every time someone pays for a meal, saves another person's life, provides shelter, lends money, takes a job, or gives a gift, a line is added. Both parties know the ledger exists, however, no one wants to be the party owing more.

This is the Invisible Ledger, and it's the engine that drives economic tension in romantasy.

The ledger exists because of the expectation of love being free, yet everything costs. If one person has more wealth, more power, more resources, etc., than the other person, the ledger is already skewed, even before they get involved romantically. Every act of generosity adds a line. Every rescue adds a line. Every "don't worry about it" adds a line. And the character on the wrong side of the ledger feels it, even if they can't articulate it. This feeling affects how they move within the relationship. It causes pride when they should accept aid. This feeling creates suspicion when they should be feeling gratitude. It forces them to wonder the same question that plagues every unequal relationship: Do I love them, or am I in love with what they have invested in me?

In *A Court of Thorns and Roses*, Feyre's ledger is skewed as soon as she steps foot into the Fae world. Rhysand heals her arm Under the Mountain, so she owes him her life. He gives her a week each month at the Night Court, so she now owes him her time. With each gift he gives her (training, freedom, a place to live where she will not be controlled) the ledger grows heavier and heavier. The romance will finally become real once Feyre stops thinking about how much she owes Rhysand and starts making the conscious decision to be there. However, the shadow of the ledger will always be present. It is the reason why their early relationship was so tense, because neither of them knew if her feelings were based on love or gratitude.

In *The Cruel Prince*, the ledger is turned upside down. Jude has absolutely nothing: no magic, no standing, no protection. But she builds her leverage through her intellect, combat skills, and strategic maneuvering until she has Cardan's oath. The ledger has been flipped. Cardan is now obligated to Jude, and the question is whether his obedience is out of obligation or something else entirely.

It doesn't have to be money. The ledger can be based on magical power, social status, physical safety, or some form of political protection. What matters is that there is an inequality, and both parties are tracking it, even when they pretend they are not.

Consider what the Invisible Ledger reveals in your romance:

- **Who owes more?** At the beginning of your story, which character is more heavily weighted on the ledger? What did they receive that cannot be reciprocated in the same manner? In what way does that debt affect their behaviour; are they more guarded, more eager to prove themselves, more resentful?
- **What can't be repaid with money?** The most charged entries on the ledger are typically not financial. A life saved, a secret kept, a reputation protected. These are debts that money can't settle, and that's where the tension lives.

- **When does generosity feel like control?** There is a tipping point where “I’m helping you” starts to feel like “I own you.” The recipient of the help or favour may not be able to define the difference, but they sense it. Where is that line for your characters?
- **What would balance the ledger?** What could the less powerful character offer, provide, or risk in order for their partner to feel an equality? Sometimes it’s competence. Sometimes it’s emotional honesty. Sometimes it’s the willingness to walk away, demonstrating they’re remaining by choice and not obligation.

Your responsibility as a writer is to show the ledger. Show what is being added. Show how each side of the ledger feels. And then find the moment, the real romantic turning point, where one or both characters decide to stop counting.

That’s when the love becomes real. Not when the debt is paid, but when it stops mattering.

The Key Question

What’s the single biggest entry on your characters’ Invisible Ledger: the one debt, gift, or sacrifice that neither of them can forget? And what will it take for them to stop letting it define the relationship?

What’s on your characters’ Invisible Ledger?

Map the emotional debt between your characters. What has been given or received, who gave, who owes, and how does the debt feel?

YOUR ANSWER

When does the ledger stop mattering?

What moment, scene, or choice makes one or both characters decide they’re done keeping score? This is your romantic turning point. Make it earn its weight.

How Economics Works in Romantasy

Economics in romantasy typically creates tension through imbalance, pressure, and transaction. Money isn't just money. It's power, security, freedom, and control.

Economic Imbalance

When one character has significantly more wealth than the other:

- Power dynamics shift. Who depends on whom?
- Generosity can feel like control
- Pride and shame enter the relationship
- The question “do they love me or my money?” haunts the wealthy

Economic Pressure

When financial necessity forces choices:

- Arranged marriages for money or alliance
- Accepting employment from a love interest
- Choosing security over love (or love over security)
- Debt creating obligation

Economic Transaction

When money or resources pass between lovers:

- Gifts carry meaning beyond their value
- Help can feel like charity
- Refusal can feel like rejection
- “I owe you” creates imbalance

Which economic mechanism is doing the most work in your romance?

Imbalance, pressure, and transaction often overlap, but one usually dominates. Naming it helps you write it with intention rather than accidentally.

Which economic mechanisms drive your romance — imbalance (one has more), pressure (necessity forces choices), or transaction (resources pass between them)? How does each show up, and which scenes does it drive?

YOUR ANSWER

Common Patterns: Economics in Romantasy

PATTERN	HOW IT WORKS	WHAT IT CREATES
The wealth gap	One character rich, one poor	Power imbalance; questions about motives
The economic rescue	Wealthy character can solve poor character's problems	Gratitude vs. obligation; "am I being bought?"
The arrangement	Financial necessity forces proximity	Forced proximity; "is this real?"
The debt	One owes the other (money, life, service)	Obligation; when is the debt paid?
The sacrifice	One gives up wealth/security for love	High stakes; proving love isn't about money
The inheritance threat	Being together means losing fortune	External pressure; choosing love or security

Which economic pattern(s) drive your romance?

Most romances use one or two of these as primary engines and touch on others as secondary tension. Naming your pattern helps you build the right exercises and avoid the common mistake of having economic tension that's stated but never shown.

PATTERN	PRIMARY OR SECONDARY?	HOW IT APPEARS IN YOUR STORY
The wealth gap		
The economic rescue		
The arrangement		
The debt		
The sacrifice		
The inheritance threat		

These common themes show up consistently in commercially successful romantasy. The wealth gap provides the main conflict in *The Cruel Prince*, where Jude is a powerless mortal in a world of wealthy, powerful Fae, and her only capital is her ability to lie and her willingness to fight. Debt is also central to *ACOTAR*, where Feyre's bargain with Rhysand creates obligation that blurs into something else entirely. The arrangement appears in *From Blood and Ash*, where Poppy's role as the Maiden makes her a political and economic asset to be traded.

And the sacrifice runs through *Bridgerton*, where characters repeatedly face the choice between advantageous matches and the people they actually want.

It's interesting to note how many of these romances conclude. The romantic arc often acts as the vehicle for the subversion of class structures. Feyre is literally brought back to life by the High Lords, and her transition from a starving human to a High Lady represents a true "rags-to-riches" story fueled by her romantic entanglement within the upper echelon of society. Jude and Cardan's relationship subverts the hierarchical structure of the Fae by creating a mutually beneficial and equally politicised relationship that ultimately rejects the master-servant dynamic of Elfhame. Violet and Xaden's relationship in *Fourth Wing* bridges the gaps created by the various military factions, while Vin's relationship with Elend in *Mistborn* elevates her from being a street urchin to being the leader of a revolution through their shared Allomantic abilities. While the specific pattern is less important than what you do with it, how far you allow the economic factors to complicate the emotional factors involved in the romance and if the romance supports the status quo of the economy or if it disrupts it is really your main issue.

A Note Before You Begin

Not every question will apply to your story. Skip what doesn't.

If your world mirrors a historical economy, focus on what's different. Zero in on what deviates from reader expectations and what specifically creates tension for your romance.

Economics can stay in the background. If your obstacles are political, magical, or cultural rather than economic, develop just enough economy to make the world feel real.

Common Mistakes with Economic Worldbuilding

Mistake #1: The Meaningless Wealth Gap

One character is rich and one is poor, but it never affects anything. The poor character has no financial pressures. Economic difference creates stakes only when it has real consequences.

FIX

Make the gap mean something. The poor character faces real scarcity. The rich character's money affects the power dynamic.

Mistake #2: The Infinite Wealth

The wealthy character can buy their way out of any problem. Money is never actually a constraint. Stakes require constraints. If wealth solves everything, the story loses tension.

FIX

Give wealth limits. Their money is tied up, controlled by family, or comes with strings. Or money simply can't solve this particular problem.

Mistake #3: The Invisible Economy

Characters exist in an economic vacuum. Nobody seems to work or worry about money. **Check your work against the common mistakes.** *These three traps catch even experienced writers. Be honest — if you spot one, that's a good thing. It means you can fix it now rather than three drafts from now.* | Mistake | Am I Doing This? | How I'll Fix It | |—|—| | *The Meaningless Wealth Gap — one character is rich, one is poor, but it never affects anything* | Yes — my FMC is poor but it only comes up in chapter 1 | Add a scene where she can't afford medicine and has to accept help from the love interest, triggering a pride spiral | | *The Meaningless Wealth Gap — one character is rich, one is poor, but it never creates consequences* | | | *The Infinite Wealth — the wealthy character can buy their way out of any problem* | | | *The Invisible Economy — nobody seems to work or worry about money* | | |

FIX

Ground characters in economic reality. Readers should understand how they survive. Choices have economic consequences.

Economic Systems

What type of economy exists in your world?

Think about how the economic system shapes daily life and what opportunities exist for your characters. Does it allow for social mobility, or are people locked into their station?

TYPE	✓	HOW WEALTH WORKS	HOW IT SHAPES ROMANCE
Feudal/Agrarian		Land-based wealth; peasants work land owned by lords	Rigid class barriers between lovers; land as dowry or

TYPE	✓	HOW WEALTH WORKS	HOW IT SHAPES ROMANCE
			inheritance; a character's worth tied to what they own
Mercantile/Trade		Wealth from commerce; merchant class rising	New money vs. old blood tension; a merchant who can buy anything except status; trade routes that create distance
Guild-Based		Professions controlled by guilds; must apprentice	Forbidden to marry outside the guild; apprentice/master power dynamics; secrets that can't be shared with outsiders
Magical Economy		Magic is primary source of wealth/production	Magical ability as class marker; a non-magical partner seen as "marrying down"; one character's power literally sustaining the other
Scarcity/Survival		Resources desperately scarce; survival is primary concern	Love as luxury you can't afford; choosing a partner for survival rather than desire; sharing resources as intimacy

Which type (or combination) describes your world?

Your economic system determines what obstacles exist for your characters. A feudal economy locks them into class; a guild economy locks them into profession. Name it so you can build from it.

YOUR ANSWER

How is wealth created in your world?

The source of wealth determines who has it — and who your characters have to fight, serve, or charm to get it. A world where wealth comes from magic creates different romantic obstacles than one where wealth comes from land.

Agriculture? Trade? Craftsmanship? Mining? Magic? Conquest?

YOUR ANSWER

How is wealth distributed?

Concentrated wealth means a wider gap between your leads — and more people invested in keeping them apart.

Relatively equal? Concentrated among few? Regional variation? Class-based?

YOUR ANSWER

How does wealth move?

If wealth can only be inherited, your poor character can't earn their way up — marriage or magic might be the only paths. If wealth can be earned, ambition becomes a romantic complication.

Can it be earned through work? Only inherited? Granted by rulers? Won through conquest?

YOUR ANSWER

Economic Conditions

Is the economy currently stable, growing, or in crisis?

Prosperity? Slow decline? Post-war rebuilding? Famine or shortage? On the brink of collapse?

YOUR ANSWER

What economic pressures affect ordinary people right now?

Inflation? Scarcity? Heavy taxation? Unemployment? War disruption?

YOUR ANSWER

How do current economic conditions pressure your romance?

A war economy, famine, or recession doesn't just set the backdrop — it creates urgency. If the world is collapsing, falling in love might feel irresponsible, or it might be the only thing worth holding onto.

YOUR ANSWER

If Your Economy Runs on Magic

Your magical abilities are an economic engine; therefore, your economies are deeply personal. Each person's body, power and being is the commodity. It is a different way of understanding how money and love function together.

This isn't hypothetical, either. As many authors write in modern romantasy and fantasy, magic typically serves as the actual economy: as labour, as currency, as the determinant of who has food on their table and who will go hungry. So you need to determine how your magical system will create economic winners and losers and what that will mean for the couple that wants to be with one another despite the economic divide.

How is magical power produced?

Magic has to come from somewhere, and where it comes from determines who pays the cost. There are broadly three models:

MODEL	HOW IT WORKS	WHO BENEFITS	WHO PAYS	ROMANTASY EXAMPLE
Magic as labour	Power is generated through personal effort, exertion, or sacrifice	Those with endurance, training, or natural talent	The individual wizard; their body is the fuel	In Naomi Novik's <i>Scholomance</i> , mana is produced through physical and mental drudgery. Every spell costs somebody's effort. The fitter you get, the harder you have to work to generate the same mana. There's no shortcut.
Magic as inheritance	Power passes through bloodlines, is gifted by the land, or is biologically determined	Those born into the right family, species, or caste	Everyone excluded by birth	In <i>ACOTAR</i> , the High Fae inherit magical power through blood. High Lords are chosen by the land's magic itself. The Lesser Fae are structurally locked into servant roles regardless of

MODEL	HOW IT WORKS	WHO BENEFITS	WHO PAYS	ROMANTASY EXAMPLE
				individual merit.
Magic as commodity	Power is stored in objects, substances, or transferable units that can be bought, sold, or stolen	Those with wealth to purchase magical materials	Those forced to sell their power, their labour, or their very life force	In Sanderson's <i>Stormlight Archive</i> , currency is literally gemstones infused with magical energy. In <i>Warbreaker</i> , every person is born with one Breath that can be sold, meaning the wealthy can buy the souls of the poor.

The type of model you use will have major effects on the development of the romance in your story. If magic is labour, then a very strong character is also a very tired character and the romantic partner that gives them a break from all they are doing, that assists them, that recognises the price they pay for that great spell, is going to be an important part of the story in a very personal way. If magic is based on birthright, your romance is working against a social caste system. When a person with magical ability falls in love with someone that is considered beneath them socially, they risk losing their own standing within society. And if magic is a commodity, love can be confused with commerce: is a gift of magical power an act of love or an act of purchase? In *Fourth Wing*, the state controls magical labour absolutely. Navarre funnels its magically gifted citizens through Basgiath War College, where dragon riders become elite military assets and everyone else becomes expendable infantry. You don't get to decide if you're going to be a dragon rider or not; it's decided for you and you can lose your life in this decision. In the *Scholomance*, Enclaves are analogous to corporations: the wealthy class lives safely behind magical barriers and the independently operating wizards give up their magical abilities in exchange for a secure place to live. The pattern continues to repeat itself. Those at the top

of the structure accumulate the majority of the magical resources. Those at the bottom of the structure do the hard, dangerous work.

What happens to the magically ungifted?

An economy based on magic means people who don't have it aren't just financially impoverished. They're structurally excluded. How would this affect a romance between two individuals whose one has a gift and the other doesn't?

Jude in *The Cruel Prince* is a human living in Elfhome, a world where the Fae can glamour humans into mindless servants, stripping them of will and identity. Being non-magical puts Jude at a risk of being enslaved, which goes beyond mere poverty. The only advantages she has over the Fae are that she can lie (the Fae can't) and she's been trained to fight. When she falls for Cardan, a Fae prince, there is more than just an emotional difference between them. It's existential. He belongs to the species that can erase her mind with a thought.

In *ACOTAR*, the social hierarchy is based on biology: the High Fae are beautiful, powerful, long-lived, and legally protected. The Lesser Fae are responsible for all of the menial jobs such as cooking, cleaning, and maintenance. When Hybern attacks the Summer Court, the High Fae lock themselves in the upper areas of the kingdom and leave the Lesser Fae in the lower areas to be killed. The message is loud and clear. All that matters is how much magical blood runs through your veins.

If magic can be extracted, stored, or stolen, then magical characters aren't just workers. They're resources. The level of romantic tension present in these novels is extreme: does your love interest view you as a person or a potential resource?

What happens to the magically ungifted in your world?

If your economy runs on magic, people who lack it aren't just poor — they're structurally locked out. What does this mean for daily survival? And if one of your leads is ungifted while the other is powerful, the gap between them isn't just financial. It's existential.

YOUR ANSWER

In *Warbreaker*, Breaths are transferable. You can literally sell your soul's life force to someone wealthier. In the *Stormlight Archive*, Stormlight is stored in gemstones that slowly leak energy, creating an economy where magical currency has a built-in expiration date and must constantly circulate. And in *ACOTAR*, Amarantha

took the magical energy from the High Lords to gain greater power and created a magical recession that caused instability in many of the courts. If you live in a world where your magical abilities can be taken from you, then your romantic relationships exist under a threat. The fact that your lover's powers are coveted by others puts you and your relationship at risk.

How does magical status affect who your characters can love?

Think about the specific barriers your magic system creates:

BARRIER	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	QUESTION FOR YOUR ROMANCE
Biological essentialism	Power determined by species, bloodline, or birth	Can your characters have children? Would their children be "less than"?
Institutional gatekeeping	Access to magic controlled by schools, military, guilds	Does the institution forbid relationships across rank or quadrant?
Economic exclusion	Magic costs money to fuel or access	Can the less wealthy character ever be an equal partner?
Lifespan disparity	Magical beings live centuries; non-magical partners age and die	Is the Fae character watching their human lover grow old?
Glamour/mental control	One species can psychically dominate the other	How does the human partner trust that their feelings are real?

Can magic create wealth or resources?

If magic can solve money problems, you need a reason it doesn't — otherwise your characters' economic struggles feel artificial. The limitation you choose here becomes a plot constraint that keeps your romance under pressure.

Transmuting materials? Summoning resources? Faster production? Healing for pay? Magical transportation?

YOUR ANSWER

If yes, why isn't everyone rich?

This is where you close the loophole. The best answers create romantic tension: magic costs something personal (a healer who shortens their own life), magic is restricted by the powerful (a guild that serves the rich), or magic ability is rare (one character has it and the other doesn't, creating envy or dependence).

Scarcity of mages? Magic costs something (health, lifespan, sanity)? Laws restrict it? Requires rare ability or training?

YOUR ANSWER

What magical labor is economically valuable?

Magical services people pay for tell you where magical characters sit in the economy — and what they're worth to others. A love interest who's a paid healer has different leverage than one who's a court enchanter.

What magical services do people pay for?

YOUR ANSWER

Who controls magical economic power?

Whoever controls magical labour controls magical people. If your mage character answers to a guild, a government, or a magical family, that's a leash on their freedom — and a constraint on who they can love and how openly they can love them.

Guilds? Government? Individual mages? Magical families?

YOUR ANSWER

Currency & Scale

What currency exists?

You don't need a full monetary system — but knowing what your coins are called and roughly what they're worth lets you write scenes where money feels real. A character counting coppers hits differently than a character vaguely "being poor."

Coins (what metals, what denominations)? Paper money? Trade goods as currency? Magical currency?

YOUR ANSWER

What's the rough scale of money?

Readers need to feel the weight of money in your story. What costs would make your protagonist wince, and what would your love interest spend without thinking? You don't need a full monetary system. You need enough for readers to feel the gap when one character drops coins casually and the other counts every one.

ITEM	APPROXIMATE COST
Day's unskilled labour wage	
Simple meal	
Night at an inn	

ITEM	APPROXIMATE COST
A decent horse	
A year's comfortable living	

Examples:

ITEM	APPROXIMATE COST
Day's unskilled labour wage	5 copper pieces; a skilled craftsman earns 2 silver
Simple meal	2 copper at a tavern; 1 copper from a street vendor

What's your currency called?

A few details about currency can make your world feel lived-in. What's stamped on a coin tells readers something about who's in power. What materials are used tells them what's valued. Perhaps gold coins show the king's face, or copper tokens bear a guild's symbol. Names often reflect history, rulers, or cultural values. A coin called a "blessing" implies different values than one called a "skull."

DENOMINATION	MATERIAL	VALUE	WHAT'S DEPICTED

Examples:

DENOMINATION	MATERIAL	VALUE	WHAT'S DEPICTED
Crown	Gold	100 coppers	Reigning monarch on front, royal crest on back
Talon	Silver	10 coppers	Griffin clutching a sword
Bit	Copper	Base unit	Sheaf of wheat

How do people conduct trade?

The method of trade shapes how your characters interact with money — and with each other. Barter creates face-to-face negotiation. Credit creates invisible debt. Magical contracts create supernatural enforcement. Each one affects the romance differently.

Coin? Barter? Credit? Letters of exchange? Magical contracts?

YOUR ANSWER

Are there trade restrictions that matter?

Trade restrictions are ready-made romantic obstacles. If the guild says she can't sell to outsiders and he's an outsider, that's a wall between them that neither of them built.

Guilds controlling who can sell what? Import/export restrictions? Illegal goods?

YOUR ANSWER

How does your currency system show the gap between your characters?

The scale of money matters most when readers can feel the difference between your characters. If a night at an inn costs 5 coppers and your protagonist earns 3 coppers a day, the reader instantly understands what it means when the love interest drops a gold crown without thinking. What specific price point makes the gap visceral?

(Your response here)

Wealth & Class

What does wealth look like at different levels?

Show the gap through concrete details. What does each character's home look like? What do they eat? What small luxuries does one take for granted that the other dreams of?

LEVEL	WHAT LIFE LOOKS LIKE
Wealthy/Elite	
Comfortable	

LEVEL	WHAT LIFE LOOKS LIKE
Getting by	
Struggling	
Impoverished	

Examples:

LEVEL	WHAT LIFE LOOKS LIKE
Wealthy/Elite	Multiple estates, servants for every task, never think about cost, can influence laws
Struggling	One missed harvest from hunger, mending clothes repeatedly, sharing rooms with strangers

Can people change their economic class?

Through work? Marriage? Education? Magical ability? Or is class fixed at birth? The answer to this question determines whether your romance is fighting against a wall or a fence. One can be climbed. The other can't.

YOUR ANSWER

What does wealth provide beyond money?

Access to education? Political influence? Legal protection? Better marriage prospects? Leisure time?

YOUR ANSWER

What does poverty mean concretely?

What can't poor people access? What dangers do they face? What choices don't they have?

YOUR ANSWER

If mobility is possible, what's the path?

If your characters come from different classes, social mobility is the escape hatch — or the false promise. Can your less wealthy character actually climb, or is the system rigged? This determines whether “we’ll find a way” is realistic or delusional.

YOUR ANSWER

If mobility is impossible, what keeps people locked in place?

The thing that keeps your characters apart isn’t just personal opposition — it’s structural. Name the structures. The more specific you get, the harder the obstacle feels, and the more satisfying it is when love finds a way through.

Legal restrictions? Economic barriers? Social enforcement?

YOUR ANSWER

Resources & Scarcity

Building on Section 1

Your Resource Foundation In Section 1: Resources & Territorial Control, you mapped where resources are found and who controls them. Now we'll explore how that control creates economic stakes and romantic tension.

What's the single most valuable resource in your world?

The thing people would kill for, die for, or sell their freedom for. Now ask: does either of your main characters control it, need it, or threaten someone's access to it? That's where the romantic stakes live.

YOUR ANSWER

Why is it scarce?

The reason for scarcity tells you who's to blame — and whether your characters are on the same side of that blame. Natural rarity is nobody's fault. Controlled distribution means someone is hoarding, and your characters might be on opposite sides of that injustice.

Natural rarity? Controlled distribution? Difficult to produce? Dangerous to obtain?

YOUR ANSWER

What resources are essential for survival?

Survival needs create desperation, and desperation drives romance plots. If your character can't afford medicine, they might accept help from someone they don't trust. If clean water is controlled by the love interest's family, every sip is a reminder of the power imbalance.

Food, water, shelter, fuel, medicine — what do people need to live?

YOUR ANSWER

What resources are scarce or valuable?

What is the most valuable resource in your world? Why is it valuable, and who controls it?

YOUR ANSWER

How do your world's primary resources shape the romantic landscape?

Resources don't just create cultures. They create the conditions for love stories. Scarcity forces desperate choices. Abundance creates power to hoard or share. Control of a resource is control of people's lives.

RESOURCE	HOW IT SHAPES CULTURE	HOW IT SHAPES ROMANCE
Timber	Carpentry valued, forests sacred, wooden architecture	Territorial disputes separating lovers; sacred forests as forbidden meeting places
Gold/Precious metals	Mining economy, ornate craftsmanship, wealth displays	Wealth gap made visible; gold as bride price; miners' dangerous lives
Wool/Textiles	Weaving traditions, nomadic herders, vibrant markets	Nomadic vs. settled tension; textile trade creating travel and distance
Grain/Agriculture	Harvest festivals, farming cycles dictate life, land ownership	Land as dowry; failed harvests forcing desperate marriages; harvest festivals as romantic settings
Salt	Preservation culture, salt mining communities	Control of essential resource as political leverage in marriage negotiations
Fish/Sea	Coastal culture, sailing traditions, sea worship	Sailors gone for months; port romances; sea as barrier between lovers
Gemstones	Jewellery crafting traditions, gem-based status symbols	Gems as courtship gifts; mining wealth vs. old nobility; gemstone magic tied to bonds

Work & Occupations

Reference: Fantasy Professions & Jobs

Use this list for inspiration. What work shapes your characters' daily lives, and what romantic friction does it create?

CATEGORY	EXAMPLES	ROMANTIC TENSION
Nobility & Governance	Lord/lady, steward, ambassador, tax collector, court advisor	Duty vs. desire; political marriages; “I can’t be seen with you”
Military & Combat	Knight, soldier, guard, mercenary, assassin	Protector/protected dynamic; deployment and separation; violence as barrier to intimacy
Skilled Trades	Blacksmith, carpenter, tailor, jeweller, glassblower	Working-class pride vs. noble expectations; craft as love language
Merchants & Trade	Shopkeeper, trader, caravan master, innkeeper	Travel and distance; merchant wealth without status; “you’re buying me”
Service & Household	Servant, maid, butler, cook, lady’s maid	Power imbalance; secret relationships; “I serve you but I want you”
Healing & Medicine	Healer, midwife, herbalist, apothecary	Caretaker intimacy; touching bodies professionally; “I healed you, now I can’t stop caring”
Religious & Spiritual	Priest, priestess, monk, oracle, shrine maiden	Forbidden desire; vows of celibacy; divine duty vs. mortal love
Magical Professions	Court mage, hedge witch, enchanter, potion-maker, ward-smith	Magic as class marker; bonded service; “my power is the only thing you value”
Scholarly & Learned	Scribe, scholar, tutor, librarian, alchemist	Intellectual equals from different worlds; tutor/student tension
Underworld & Shadows	Thief, smuggler, spy, bounty hunter, poisoner	Secret lives; moral conflict; “if you knew what I really do”

Work is a physical part of people as well as their thoughts. It can be shown through how your body looks (the calluses on your hands or the ink on your fingers), what you know (your ability to see things that are invisible to others) and the routines you go through (actions you've developed over time because they have become reflexive). A blacksmith knows whether metal has been worked well or poorly. A merchant will calculate the worth of an item with little effort. A soldier will assess a potential threat in less than one second upon entering a room. When characters from different work worlds meet, let them discover each other through these competencies. There's real intimacy in watching someone do what they're good at, and in being seen doing what you're good at by someone who appreciates it.

What professions are respected? Looked down upon?

Occupational status shapes how people are treated and what doors open or close. If your characters have different occupations, how might society view their pairing?

STATUS	OCCUPATIONS
Highly respected	
Respectable/ ordinary	
Necessary but low- status	
Disreputable or shameful	

Examples:

STATUS	OCCUPATIONS
Highly respected	Court mages, master healers, high priests, landed nobility
Disreputable or shameful	Hedge witches, fortune-tellers, gravediggers, money-lenders

What work do most people do?

The baseline tells you what's normal — and normal is important because your characters' deviations from it are what create tension. If most people farm, a character who refuses to farm is making a statement.

In an agrarian society, most people farm. In a trade economy, many are merchants, sailors, or craftspeople.

What's the baseline?

YOUR ANSWER

What occupations exist in your world?

List occupations that appear or matter in your story:

Describe 2-3 key occupations in your world. For each, what do they do, what is their social status, and who typically does this work?

YOUR ANSWER

What dangerous or unpleasant work exists?

Dangerous work creates specific romantic tension: the fear of loss, the physical toll on the body, the secrecy about what the job really involves. If your character does dangerous work, their partner lives with that fear. Mining? Soldiering? Magical labor with costs? Work that shortens lives?

YOUR ANSWER

How People Enter Occupations

How do people end up in their occupations?

The path into work shapes your characters' backstories and creates constraints. A character locked into a trade by birth has different options than one who chose their profession — and different resentments.

PATH INTO WORK	EXISTS IN YOUR WORLD?	WHO TAKES THIS PATH	ROMANTIC IMPLICATIONS
<i>Born into it (family trade, caste)</i>	<i>Yes — blacksmith families, farming families</i>	<i>Most commoners</i>	<i>Character can't leave their work to be with someone from another world</i>
Apprenticeship			
Education/academy			
Military/conscription			
Magical selection			
Economic necessity			
Other:			

Can people change occupations?

If your protagonist is stuck in a job they hate, can they leave? If leaving means losing everything — guild membership, family ties, their only income — that's a constraint the romance has to navigate.

Is mobility possible, or are you locked into your work for life?

YOUR ANSWER

What does your protagonist do to survive?

Work shapes who we become. What skills, knowledge, and worldview has their occupation given them?

Describe your protagonist's occupation: What do they do? What skills have they learned through work? How does the work show on their body? What do they notice that others don't because of their training?

YOUR ANSWER

What does your love interest do to survive?

How does their work connect to or conflict with your protagonist's world? Do their occupations create proximity or distance?

Describe your love interest's occupation: What do they do? What skills have they learned through work? How does the work show on their body? What do they notice that others don't because of their training?

YOUR ANSWER

Your Characters' Economic Positions

Where does your protagonist fall economically?

Their economic position shapes what they worry about, what they dream of, and what they would sacrifice for security or freedom.

Describe your protagonist's economic position: What is their economic status, source of income, economic security, and economic autonomy?

YOUR ANSWER

Where does your love interest fall economically?

How does their economic reality differ from your protagonist's? What assumptions do they make about money that might clash or align?

Describe your love interest's economic position: What is their economic status, source of income, economic security, and economic autonomy?

YOUR ANSWER

If there's a gap, how significant is it?

Minor difference? Significant gap? Extreme disparity?

YOUR ANSWER

The Wealth Gap Dynamic

If you create different socio-economic statuses for your characters, that tension runs deeper than “one has money, one doesn’t.” Wealth-gap romance novels that are most compelling do not gloss over the issue of money and instead address the issues presented by it.

You want to show the gap of wealth through the smaller issues as much as you can. The wealthy character casually ordering something the other couldn’t afford in a month. The poor character flinching at prices. You want to show both ways that the characters see each other: the wealthy character’s obliviousness (not unkind, just inexperienced), and the poor character’s knowledge the wealthy one lacks (how to stretch food, read a room for danger, survive without protection). When the wealth gap causes tension, do not let the tension go away quickly. Give the characters time to struggle with their feelings of pride and obligations and how money can complicate many aspects of relationships. When done well, wealth-gap romance novels should give the reader a feeling of both perspectives.

In *ACOTAR*, the author does not present Feyre’s poverty as mere background information. Rather, it is the driving force behind the storyline. She hunts in the frozen wilderness to provide for her starving family. When she enters the Fae world, the contrast is visceral: endless food, impossible luxury, beauty she couldn’t have imagined. Even after Feyre is able to enter the world of the Fae, the wealth gap between the two worlds is still there, but it has changed the way Feyre views herself and what she thinks she deserves.

This is where the “protective debt” comes in. A powerful character such as Rhysand using his vast magical and material resources to protect Feyre creates a romantic gesture, but it also creates unease. She did not ask to be protected. She cannot reciprocate at the same level of magnitude. The protective gesture creates a debt that she cannot pay back equally, and the question remains if she is being his partner or his ward because of his resources. The best wealth-gap romance novels find themselves in that unease and do not quickly resolve it.

In *Fourth Wing*, the dynamic is similar but institutional: Violet’s family name gives her access to Basgiath, but her physical fragility makes her dependent on Xaden’s protection in a system where a single dragon rider is worth an entire infantry company. That he is willing to use his position to shield her is romantic, but it also reinforces the social structure of value placed on his life over hers.

What can the wealthier character provide that the other can’t access alone?

Safety? Comfort? Opportunity? Legal protection? Social access?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the less wealthy character bring that money can't buy?

Skills? Knowledge? Magical ability? Street smarts? Moral clarity?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the wealth gap affect their power dynamic?

Does one depend on the other? Is there resentment? Does the wealthy one use money as control?

YOUR ANSWER

How do they each feel about the gap?

Shame? Guilt? Obliviousness? Resentment? These feelings may never be spoken aloud, but they shape every interaction.

How does each character feel about the wealth gap between them, and how do they show it (or hide it)?

YOUR ANSWER

Money, Gifts & What They Mean

The problem with giving money or expensive items to people we care about is that there is no clear-cut answer. For the giver, a gift can be an expression of care, or a substitute for harder things. For the receiver, it can feel like love made tangible, or like charity.

The tension in financial offers lives in the moment of decision. Take your time when one character offers and the other must respond. Show the internal calculation: the receiver weighing need against pride, wondering what accepting means. Show the giver noticing this hesitation, possibly trying to ease the situation, or making it even worse. The words matter. “Let me help” versus “You need this” versus “It’s nothing” all carry different weights. After an offer is accepted or refused, show the aftermath: the lingering awkwardness, the shift in how they see each other. A refusal to give an item can hurt the giver, while acceptance can bind the recipient. Neither is easy.

The most effective gift scenes in romantasy do not focus on expensive objects, but rather on being seen. Consider the difference between a character receiving jewellery they did not request (this could be viewed as the giver buying them), and receiving something relatively inexpensive that shows the giver listened. The gift that says “I noticed what you needed and I remembered” carries more romantic weight than a chest of gold. And when a gift falls flat, and actually makes the distance between the characters greater instead of closer, that’s tension you can use.

What does it mean in your culture for one person to give money or expensive gifts to another?

Romantic? Controlling? Insulting? Expected? Does meaning differ based on who gives and who receives?

YOUR ANSWER

When is a gift generous, and when is it an attempt to buy someone?

Where’s the line?

YOUR ANSWER

If the wealthier character offers to pay for something, how does the other feel?

Grateful? Humiliated? Obligated? Suspicious of motives?

YOUR ANSWER

What would it mean for the less wealthy character to refuse help?

Pride? Independence? Proving the relationship isn't about money? What would they sacrifice by refusing?

YOUR ANSWER

Has money created a misunderstanding or conflict between your characters?

A gift taken wrong? An offer that insulted? A refusal that hurt?

YOUR ANSWER

What financial gesture would be genuinely romantic, not transactional?

Not buying something expensive, but noticing what they need and providing it without being asked. The gesture that says “I see you” rather than “I can afford this.”

YOUR ANSWER

Marriage as Economic Contract

In most romantasy worlds, marriage isn't just about love. It's a financial transaction, a political alliance, a transfer of property and power. This collision between what the heart wants and what the contract demands is one of the genre's most potent sources of tension.

How much the "cost" of marrying varies depending on the world in which the story takes place; however, the essence of the tension is the same. When marriage has a price, love has a cost.

In *Bridgerton*, the Marriage Mart is the economic engine of the entire social world. A family's wealth is generated through property and capital yields, and for women of the aristocracy, marriage is the only path to financial stability. The large dowries of the Bridgerton daughters make them highly attractive targets, but that attractiveness comes with risk: fortune hunters who want the capital, not the person. Essentially, the social season is a marketplace where a woman's value rises and falls with every public interaction.

The tension isn't subtle. Participating in the market requires enormous investment. And the stakes of failure, remaining unmarried, mean not just social embarrassment but genuine financial precarity. Characters who choose security over passion do so because the alternative is poverty. This is the kind of economic pressure your marriage system should generate: the choice between a loveless arrangement that keeps you fed and a risky gamble on genuine feeling.

Marriage Contracts in Fantasy: Beyond the Historical

Romantasy has taken those historical elements and amplified them with magic. So the contract is not just transferring money; it could be binding two people together spiritually, obliging someone to obey another person, or creating some form of supernatural punishment if the terms of the contract are broken. What this does is make the stakes much higher than what would have been possible in historical fiction.

Where the contract becomes an interesting place to create romantic tension is where there is a disconnect between the obligations of the contract and what the heart is telling you. The contract says "obligation." The heart says something else. In *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy must decide whether to trust Casteel, a man who deceived her, who initially saw her as a political asset, even as their strategic marriage evolves into genuine devotion. In *ACOTAR*, Feyre's growing love for Rhysand is complicated by the fact that she's literally contractually obligated to spend time with him. Whether or not her feelings for him are true, or whether they are simply a result of the proximity of the two, is left to the reader to determine until the end of the series.

The flip side is equally powerful: characters who use the contract to achieve agency. Jude Duarte doesn't marry Cardan. She binds him. Emilia signs a soul contract not for love but for information. Poppy accepts Casteel's proposal not because she loves him (yet) but because it's her best path to freedom. These female protagonists are showing readers that a woman can be smart enough and strong enough to play the transactional game.

Two Models of Navigating Marriage Economics

The Cruel Prince has two very different approaches to marriage economics represented by the twin sisters Jude and Taryn. Taryn wants to be safe through assimilation so she marries Locke in an attempt to belong in order to gain some level of control. This doesn't work for her. Locke uses marriage as a game, he tests her

loyalty through cruel treatment, he dulls her ability to resist him with faerie fruit. Through his actions, Locke

Is your protagonist’s marriage being negotiated for economic reasons?

If so, the romance is fighting against a contract. That contract needs teeth: real consequences for breaking it. Lost land, broken alliances, financial ruin for a family, magical backlash, a soul forfeit. The stronger the contract’s grip, the higher the stakes for choosing love instead.

How does your protagonist navigate the contract?

Does she submit to it, subvert it, or use it as a tool for her own goals? The answer shapes what kind of heroine she is, and what kind of romance you’re writing.

STRATEGY	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	WHAT IT COSTS
Accept and redefine	Enter the arrangement, then transform it from within	Risk of losing yourself to the role; the line between performing and becoming
Refuse and rebel	Reject the contract entirely, face the consequences	Financial ruin, exile, loss of family protection
Game the system	Use the contract’s own rules to achieve your goals	Moral compromise; the danger of becoming what you’re fighting against

If your world uses magical contracts or bonds, define the terms:

If your characters are bound by a contract, bargain, or magical bond: What kind of bond is it? Who initiated it and why? What are the exact terms? What happens if someone breaks it? Is consummation required? Can the bond be felt physically or mentally?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the contract force them to do that they wouldn't choose freely?

Forced proximity only creates tension if it's genuinely forced. What specific obligation does the contract impose: living together, appearing in public as a couple, physical contact, sharing information?

At what moment does the contract stop being the reason they stay?

This is the romantic turning point. The obligation hasn't changed, but the motivation has. When does "I have to be here" become "I want to be here"? How does each character recognise that shift, in themselves or in the other?

For each character: When does the contract or arrangement stop being the reason they stay, and how do they realise it?

YOUR ANSWER

Inheritance & Economic Marriage

What does each character stand to inherit?

What does each character stand to inherit — or what have they been denied?

YOUR ANSWER

Does marrying the “right” or “wrong” person affect inheritance?

Can they be disinherited? Do they inherit more for marrying strategically?

YOUR ANSWER

Does your culture have dowries, bride prices, or marriage payments?

Who pays whom, and how does this create obstacles?

YOUR ANSWER

Is either character being pressured to marry for economic reasons?

By whom? What would they lose by refusing?

YOUR ANSWER

Debt, Obligation & Economic Coercion

Debt has a way of establishing a relationship long before there is a relationship. The problem with debt in romance is that it muddies the waters regarding consent. Every time one character owes another, whether that's money, a life debt, magical service, or years of bonded labour, every interaction is shadowed by the question: are they choosing this freely, or because they have to?

Many times in romantasy, debt is both literal and magical. A bargain tattoo that enforces compliance. A life saved that creates a supernatural obligation. A soul signed over as collateral. This allows the coercive element to be shown clearly and physically, which is exactly what makes these elements so useful for romantic tension.

Some of the best debt romances allow the reader to wonder, like the characters. If a character owes their love interest a life debt, and then falls in love with them, is that true love or is it gratitude dressed up as love? Don't answer this too quickly. Let the indebted character wrestle with it. Let the creditor worry about it. As soon as one of them says "forget the debt," is that generosity or manipulation? Is that liberating or just another form of bondage? Debt is only as effective as the awareness of its existence among both characters, and when neither party knows how to get around it.

In *ACOTAR*, Feyre's bargain with Rhysand is enforced by a tattoo on her hand and by the magic itself. She must spend one week per month at the Night Court. She didn't enter into the contract voluntarily (she was dying), and the creditor is also the love interest. Every moment of developing intimacy between them is shrouded by the question: would she still be here if she weren't contractually required?

In *Kingdom of the Wicked*, the debt is even more extreme. Emilia accidentally soul-binds herself to the demon prince Wrath through a mistranslated spell, then intentionally signs a blood contract with Pride, staking her very soul as collateral. Both contracts vie for control. Consummating one bond would void the other. Her body, her choices, even the act of physical intimacy become legal manoeuvres in a system of demonic debt management. That's debt working to its fullest potential within a romance.

Is either character in debt?

Debt creates obligation, and obligation clouds consent. Does debt to the love interest (or a third party) complicate the romance?

If a character carries a debt: To whom is it owed? For what? What happens if they can't repay? Is it magically enforced? How does the debt affect their ability to say yes or no to the romance?

YOUR ANSWER

How does this debt affect the romance?

Does it force them together? Keep them apart? Create shame or obligation between them?

YOUR ANSWER

Life Debts & Magical Obligations

In your world, can saving someone’s life create a binding debt?

A life debt between lovers poisons every tender moment with the question: is this gratitude or love? Name the debt so you can track how it shadows the romance.

TYPE OF LIFE DEBT	DOES IT EXIST IN YOUR WORLD?	HOW IS IT ENFORCED?	HOW DOES IT END?
Cultural obligation			
Magical compulsion			
Legal requirement			

TYPE OF LIFE DEBT	DOES IT EXIST IN YOUR WORLD?	HOW IS IT ENFORCED?	HOW DOES IT END?
Other:			

Does either character owe such a debt — or is owed one?

If the answer is yes, every romantic gesture between them is shadowed by obligation. The reader needs to feel that shadow before the characters can step out of it.

YOUR ANSWER

Economic Arrangements

Could economic necessity force your characters into an arrangement?

Marriage for money? Employment? Alliance for mutual benefit?

If your characters have an economic arrangement (marriage of convenience, etc.), describe: What is the arrangement? Why is it necessary? What does each party get?

YOUR ANSWER

How do they navigate the economic coercion?

Do they resent it? Accept it? Try to escape it? Fall in love despite it — or struggle to trust their feelings because of it?

YOUR ANSWER

The “Buying” Problem

Could the wealthy character simply buy their way out of obstacles? If yes, why don't they?

YOUR ANSWER

Could someone try to buy one of your characters — offer money to leave, marry someone else, betray their partner?

YOUR ANSWER

If offered money to abandon the relationship, what would each character do?

How does each character respond to the economic arrangement — what do they feel about it?

YOUR ANSWER

The Employer & The Employed

One of the most typical ways to create a romantic relationship in romantasy: an individual is employed by another person. The bodyguard working for the king or queen. A healer contracted to serve as medical officer to the war commander. The governess who has been hired to care for the children of the lord. The court mage bound to the service of the monarch.

Work allows for proximity, and proximity leads to potential romance, yet work also establishes a power dynamic that cannot be simply dismissed. The employer has the ability to terminate employment, to inflict punishment on the employee, or to destroy the employee's career. The employee may not have the freedom to decline the advances of their superior. It is your responsibility to take this conflict seriously if you are going to make the romance believable.

Does one character employ the other?

If one character employs the other: Who employs whom? What is the nature of the employment? Can the employee leave freely? What would they lose by refusing advances? What would they lose by accepting?

YOUR ANSWER

The issue of consent will always come to the fore in employer/employee romance. The reader will need to perceive that the less powerful party is making their own decisions, and there is no better method to demonstrate that than to provide them with a genuine opportunity to say no without consequence. If the employee can walk away and chooses to stay, the romance is earned. If they can't walk away, you're writing a different, darker story, which can work, but the power imbalance needs to be acknowledged, not glossed over. Show the employee pushing back, setting boundaries, asserting agency within the power structure. Show the employer recognising the imbalance and actively trying to level it. When the employer states "you don't have to" and truly means it? That's when the romance can begin.

In *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy’s position as the Maiden represents the ultimate example of the institution exerting control over an individual in the form of what could be interpreted as institutional bondage or employment. She’s not technically employed. She’s consecrated. But the economics are the same: the institution controls her body, her movement, her choices, and her future. She exists as a religious and political asset, not a person. The ceremony of her “Ascension,” presented as a sacred honour, is ultimately shown to be a vehicle of extraction for the Ascended vampyrs who rule Solis. Poppy has existed in a state of commodification since birth for the benefit of a predatory class of rulers.

When Casteel arrives as her protector, he simultaneously serves as an additional layer of institutional control and potentially as a means of escape. The reason why the romantic tension is present is due to the fact that Poppy’s agency has been completely stripped: every choice she makes toward Casteel, every secret meeting, every broken rule, is an act of rebellion against the system that owns her.

In *Fourth Wing*, the institutional control is military rather than religious, but the dynamic is similar. The state determines which individuals will become riders and which will become infantry. You do not get to choose your quadrant. You survive into it. And once you’re in the system, leaving isn’t an option. Romantic relationships between individuals of differing ranks are not only prohibited; they’re structurally dangerous.

How does your world handle employer/employee romance?

The binding mechanism matters enormously. A character who’s hired for wages faces a different power dynamic than one who’s magically bonded, indentured, or institutionally conscripted. The stronger the binding, the harder you need to work to make the consent believable.

BINDING TYPE	CAN THEY LEAVE?	WHAT MAKES CONSENT BELIEVABLE	PUBLISHED EXAMPLE
Hired for wages	Yes, but may lose livelihood	Give them a genuine exit option, and show them choosing to stay	In Tessa Dare’s <i>The Governess Game</i> , Alexandra has harboured feelings for Chase since before she became his employee. Her prior attraction establishes that her desire isn’t a product of his power over her.

BINDING TYPE	CAN THEY LEAVE?	WHAT MAKES CONSENT BELIEVABLE	PUBLISHED EXAMPLE
Bonded service / apprenticeship	Not without cost: loss of magic, status, or protection	Show the employee pushing back, setting terms, asserting expertise the employer needs	In <i>Daughter of No Worlds</i> , Tisaanah enters apprenticeship with Maxantarius to gain power, not because she wants him. He's a recluse who hates the institution binding them. Their shared outsider status and shared trauma create parity even inside the power structure.
Institutional conscription	No: the institution owns their service	Show rebellion within the system; make every act of intimacy an act of defiance	In <i>From Blood and Ash</i> , Poppy's every choice toward Casteel is a rebellion against the institution that consecrated her as a commodity. In <i>Fourth Wing</i> , romance across military rank lines isn't just forbidden; it's structurally dangerous.
Magical contract / soul oath	No: breaking the bond has	Foreground the negotiation. Show the moment one	In <i>Master of Crows</i> , Martise is a bondwoman sent to

BINDING TYPE	CAN THEY LEAVE?	WHAT MAKES CONSENT BELIEVABLE	PUBLISHED EXAMPLE
	supernatural consequences	character says “you don’t have to” and means it	spy on the sorcerer Silhara. Her freedom depends on betraying him. The romance becomes believable because Silhara’s own vulnerability, his fear of losing his soul, makes him as trapped as she is.

While there are many ways to obtain consent in power-unequal relationships, none is as convincing as the concept called “consent capital.” Consent capital is the cumulative evidence that the less powerful person has chosen their actions voluntarily. Authors create this by using three methods.

First, independent development of feelings. The employee develops feelings for the employer either before they develop the relationship or separately from the power dynamic of the relationship. Alexandra in *The Governess Game* developed a crush on the employer before she started working there. Tisaanah in *Daughter of No Worlds* enters apprenticeship for power, not for Max. The two develop feelings for each other while sharing experiences related to work and both experience similar traumas; therefore, the connection between them grows due to shared work and shared experiences, not because he has authority over her.

Second, the removal of threat. At some time the more powerful character must demonstrate that if the less powerful character refuses there will be no repercussions. The employer who says “you can leave” and means it, who would accept a “no” without any form of retaliation, removes the risk and allows the less powerful character to give a “yes” that appears legitimate. In Elizabeth Hoyt’s *Duke of Sin*, the housekeeper Bridget is the only person who can handle the Duke. She disciplines him, argues with him, and maintains her professional authority over the Duke throughout the novel. The Duke never punishes Bridget for challenging him. That is why the romance works.

Third, moral authority. Grant the less powerful character the moral upper hand. If the employee is the employer’s conscience, the person who sees right through them, calls them out, and holds them to a higher standard than themselves, then the power dynamics of the relationship shift where it truly counts. Tisaanah’s humanitarian goals push Max to see himself for the cynical person he is. An employee who is necessary to the employer’s conscience can never simply be viewed as inferior to the employer.

How do you build consent capital in your romance?

If there's a power imbalance, the reader needs evidence that the less powerful character is choosing freely.

Which of these methods are you using? You should have at least one, ideally two.

METHOD	HOW YOU'RE USING IT	SPECIFIC SCENE OR MOMENT
<i>Independent feelings (they fell for them before/separate from the power dynamic)</i>	<i>She had a crush on him before she took the job</i>	<i>The flashback in chapter 3 where she sees him at the market, before she knows who he is</i>
Independent feelings (they fell for them before/separate from the power dynamic)		
Removal of threat (the powerful character proves "no" has no consequences)		
Moral authority (the less powerful character becomes the powerful one's conscience)		

How does the power dynamic shift during the story?

The best employer/employee romances don't just acknowledge the imbalance. They track it changing. What moments equalise the relationship? When does the employee gain power the employer needs?

EQUALISATION MOMENT	HOW IT SHIFTS POWER	WHEN DOES IT HAPPEN IN YOUR STORY?
The employee demonstrates irreplaceable competence	The employer realises they can't manage without this person	

EQUALISATION MOMENT	HOW IT SHIFTS POWER	WHEN DOES IT HAPPEN IN YOUR STORY?
The employer becomes vulnerable (illness, crisis, emotional breakdown)	The employee sees behind the professional facade; caretaking inverts the hierarchy	
The employee refuses or pushes back, and the employer accepts it	Proves the employer won't punish honesty; creates space for genuine consent	
A shared crisis forces them into partnership	External threat makes rank irrelevant; they must work as equals to survive	

What does the employee know that the employer doesn't?

The less powerful character almost always has knowledge, skills, or perspective that the employer lacks. This is what prevents the romance from feeling one-directional. What does your employee bring that money and status can't provide?

What would it cost the employee to walk away?

And what would it cost them to stay? Map both sides. The answer reveals whether your romance is earned or coerced.

IF THEY WALK AWAY	IF THEY STAY
What do they lose? (income, protection, access, proximity to the person they want)	What do they risk? (reputation, autonomy, being seen as bought)
What do they gain? (freedom, self-respect, independence)	What do they gain? (security, closeness, the relationship itself)

Economic Independence & Dependence

Before the relationship, how economically independent is each character?

How economically independent is each character? Could they survive on their own?

YOUR ANSWER

How does the relationship change their economic situation?

Does one gain security? Does one lose independence? Does partnership create new opportunities or new vulnerabilities?

YOUR ANSWER

If one becomes economically dependent on the other, how do they feel about it?

Secure? Trapped? Grateful? Resentful? Anxious about what happens if the relationship ends?

YOUR ANSWER

What would each character do if the relationship ended?

Could they survive financially? Would they be ruined? Is economic fear part of what keeps them together?

YOUR ANSWER

Does economic dependence affect the power dynamic?

Does the provider hold power? Does the dependent partner resent it? How do they navigate this?

YOUR ANSWER

Labour & Occupation in Romance

What people do for work isn't just how they earn money. It's how they spend most of their waking hours, what skills they develop, and often how they see themselves.

You've already mapped your characters' occupations and economic positions in the exercises above. Now focus on how their work shapes the romance itself — the daily rhythms, the proximity or distance, and the friction between their professional worlds.

How do their occupations bring them together or keep them apart?

Same workplace? Completely separate worlds? Does one employ the other? Do their schedules mean they can only meet at midnight? The logistics of work create the logistics of love.

Same workplace? Completely separate worlds? Does one employ the other?

YOUR ANSWER

Does either character do work considered shameful for their class?

Shameful work carries a specific kind of romantic weight. If the love interest discovers what the protagonist really does, is that a betrayal of trust or an invitation to deeper intimacy? The shame shapes what they hide and what they reveal.

How does this affect them and the relationship?

YOUR ANSWER

Ambition & Economic Striving

Is either character trying to improve their economic position?

Ambition is a romantic complication all on its own. A character who's climbing socially or financially is making choices about where to spend their time, who to be seen with, and what risks to take — and a love interest can either accelerate that climb or derail it entirely.

What are they striving for, and why?

YOUR ANSWER

How does their ambition affect the relationship?

Ambition steals hours, demands compromises, and creates priorities that compete with love. But it also makes a character attractive — there's real romantic heat in watching someone pursue something with everything they have.

Does it compete for time and attention? Does the relationship help or hinder their goals? Could loving the “wrong” person cost them everything they’re working toward?

YOUR ANSWER

Could the relationship become confused with economic advancement?

This is one of the most psychologically rich questions in wealth-gap romance. If marrying the love interest would also solve your character's financial problems, both characters will wonder — maybe privately, maybe out loud — whether love and ambition are the same feeling. The reader should wonder too, at least for a while. How would each character answer the question “Is this love or is this a good deal?”

What does each character tell themselves about the economic dimension of the relationship, and what are they afraid might actually be true?

YOUR ANSWER

What would they sacrifice — the relationship or the ambition — if forced to choose?

This is the test. If you can't answer it, neither can your character — and that indecision is itself a source of tension you can use.

YOUR ANSWER

Economic Sacrifice

One of romance's most powerful beats is the moment a character gives up material security for love. Economic sacrifice proves love is real in a way words simply cannot.

Make the sacrifice concrete and visible. Not just "gave up the inheritance" but: the smaller apartment, the mended clothes, the dinner that's mostly bread. Show what daily life looks like after the sacrifice, the moments of regret and the moments of fierce certainty that it was worth it. The witness to this sacrifice matters too. When the love interest realises what their partner gave up, or when the sacrificer reveals it (or carefully doesn't reveal it, and the other discovers it anyway), that's a scene with serious emotional weight. Economic sacrifice is most powerful when it's ongoing, not a one-time grand gesture. It's choosing, every day, to live with less because what you gained matters more.

In *Bridgerton*, the tension between love and advantageous marriage runs through nearly every storyline. Characters face the choice between a match that secures their family's future and a match that makes them happy, and the consequences of choosing wrong are real. Financial ruin, social exile, a family left unprotected. That's what makes the sacrifice land: it costs something concrete, and the cost doesn't disappear after the wedding.

What economic security does each character sacrifice to be together?

What inheritance, income, protection, or opportunity do they lose by choosing each other? The sacrifice should cost enough to prove the love is real.

What does each character sacrifice economically to be together?

YOUR ANSWER

Is the sacrifice permanent or temporary?

A temporary sacrifice is a dramatic gesture. A permanent one is a life sentence. The permanence determines whether the sacrifice is a plot beat or the foundation of their entire future together.

Can they recover economically?

YOUR ANSWER

How do they survive after the sacrifice?

This is where romance meets reality. The grand gesture happened — now what? Rent is due. The pantry is empty. Show what love looks like when the money runs out.

YOUR ANSWER

Does the sacrifice create resentment or guilt?

Even a sacrifice made freely can curdle. The one who gave something up may resent it on a bad day. The one who benefited may feel guilty they can't match it. This ongoing tension is more interesting than the sacrifice itself.

YOUR ANSWER

But the sacrifice doesn't end at the climax. Keep reading — the ongoing costs of choosing love are where the best romance writing lives.

What Happens After They Choose Each Other?

The sacrifices don't stop at the climax. If a character gave up an inheritance, they need to find money for next week's food. If they were disowned, where will they go? Romantic conclusions can be very satisfying when both members of a couple recognise that choosing love has ongoing costs, and show how they navigate those costs together.

There are three categories of ongoing economic consequence that most romance and romantasy gloss over, but that the best ones use to deepen the love story.

When a couple crosses class lines, the world doesn't just disapprove. It withdraws its business. In historical romance, this means hostesses turning the lower-status partner away, peer groups refusing to share space with them, and professional networks closing their doors. But it's not just social embarrassment. For characters whose income depends on elite patronage (merchants, dressmakers, officers, anyone who serves the ruling class), being excluded from those circles means financial ruin.

The potential marriage between Benedict and Sophie in the *Bridgerton* series illustrates this precisely. Since he's a second son without a title, Benedict's economic position is already precarious. Marrying a maid would mean being cut off by society: peer groups would refuse Sophie, hostesses would blank her, and Benedict's fellow officers would shun him. They'd be forced to retire to the countryside, living in permanent social exile on a fraction of the income Benedict was raised to expect.

In Loretta Chase's *Maison Noiro*t series, the Noiro

sisters know that their dressmaking business lives and dies by reputation. One scandalous affair involving an aristocratic client could destroy everything overnight. When your livelihood depends on the goodwill of the powerful, a cross-class romance isn't just risky. It's a threat to your survival.

Disinheritance and downward mobility

The biggest economic impact of having a "bad" match in historical romance is losing your family's inheritance. This happens instantly through a new will or codicil, or through the eldest son choosing the wrong mate and the estate going to another child. Although the reasons differ in romantasy (loss of title, magical disinheritance, banishment from court), the consequences are identical. Each of these options leads to a permanent downward change in status that each of the characters has chosen and must endure on a daily basis.

What makes disinheritance so powerful within the romance genre is the "stickiness" of social status. Characters may be downwardly mobile; however, the values, customs and expectations that were shaped during their past life remain and are often difficult to shake. A noblewoman who marries a commoner still knows how to properly set the table for a formal dinner and interpret political subtext; however, she is now doing so in a two-room cottage. The conflict arises from the fact that there is a large difference between what she knows

and what she can afford. And the partner who grew up poor watches her struggle with things they’ve always managed, creating friction that neither of them expected.

When partners come from differing socioeconomic backgrounds, each brings to the relationship a unique way of thinking about money, and those habits don’t change just because they’re in love. The person who grew up in poverty may continue to hoard money, count every penny and become uncomfortable when spending money. The person who grew up in a higher income household may continue to spend money carelessly, not knowing why their partner is upset by purchases that seem completely reasonable to them. These aren’t personality flaws. They are survival techniques that each developed in their youth.

In *ACOTAR*, Feyre’s transition from starving human huntress to High Lady with access to Rhysand’s vast wealth is one of the most dramatic class jumps in romantasy. At the beginning of the series, Feyre remarks that the curtains in her bedroom at the Spring Court could feed a family for a month. However, as she becomes a part of the Night Court, her limited perception of money appears to fade, and she spends her days painting and constructing homes. Many fans of the series feel that Feyre’s transformation occurred too quickly, and that she lost contact with her roots after she began receiving luxury items and attention.

A counterexample is Nesta, whose excessive spending on wine and gambling are seen by Feyre and Rhysand as embarrassing behaviour, even though their father had spent his entire fortune to provide ships and soldiers for the war. The friction concerning who can spend money and who can criticise spending behaviour illustrates a larger issue: in cross-class relationships, money habits are rarely merely about money. They’re about identity, control, and whose version of “normal” wins.

CONSEQUENCE	HOW IT AFFECTS THEM	QUESTION FOR YOUR ROMANCE
Social ostracism	Lost patronage, closed doors, professional ruin	Whose social world do they live in now? Who still accepts them?
Disinheritance	Loss of estate, title, family support	What do they actually live on? What standard of living can they maintain?
Downward mobility	The daily reality of having less than they’re used to	What does the character who “married down” miss most? What surprises them about poverty?
Money habit friction	Different spending patterns, different fears about money	Does one partner hoard while the other spends? Who

CONSEQUENCE	HOW IT AFFECTS THEM	QUESTION FOR YOUR ROMANCE
		controls the household budget?
Impact on children	Children inherit the social stigma of the parents' choice	Will their children have access to the world one parent left behind?

What does daily life look like after the sacrifice?

Don't skip this. The most powerful romantic endings show the cost in concrete, daily terms. Map what changes for each character.

After your characters choose each other over economic security: Where do they live? What do they eat every day? Who do they still have access to? Who has shut them out? What do they miss most? What surprised them about their new reality?

YOUR ANSWER

How do they handle money differently?

Partners from different backgrounds will clash over spending. This isn't a flaw to fix. It's a source of ongoing, realistic tension that makes the relationship feel lived-in.

How do your characters' different financial backgrounds show up in daily life? For the one who grew up with less and the one with more: What do they spend freely on? What do they refuse to spend on? What purchase would start an argument? How do they feel about accepting help?

YOUR ANSWER

What moment makes the sacrifice feel worth it?

This is your earned ending. Not the wedding, not the declaration — the quiet scene where reduced circumstances feel like the right choice. Make it small and specific, and it'll hit harder than any grand gesture.

There should be a scene, maybe small, maybe private, where one character looks at their reduced circumstances and feels certain they chose right. What does that moment look like?

Poverty, Survival & Desperation

What does your less wealthy character need to survive?

Immediate needs:

YOUR ANSWER

How do they currently meet these needs?

HOW DO THEY CURRENTLY MEET THESE NEEDS?

What happens if they can't?

Starvation? Homelessness? Forced into servitude? Death?

YOUR ANSWER

What would they do to survive? How far would they go?

WHAT WOULD THEY DO TO SURVIVE? HOW FAR WOULD THEY GO?

Has desperation forced them into their current situation?

A job they hate? Dangerous work? An arrangement they don't want?

YOUR ANSWER

Does the love interest offer economic security?

If yes, does this complicate the romance? Create doubt about true feelings?

YOUR ANSWER

How does survival pressure shape the romance?

Desperation doesn't just create backstory — it creates present-tense romantic tension. A character who can't eat tomorrow makes different choices about love than one who's comfortable. Map how survival needs warp the romantic dynamic.

How does survival-level economic pressure affect the romance? Describe a specific pressure, how it affects the relationship, and a scene where this is felt.

YOUR ANSWER

Smuggling, Black Markets & Underground Economies

Not everything people do with money is legal. If you are writing about someone who is operating outside of the law (such as a smuggler, a thief, a black-market dealer, etc.) then the underground economy is no longer just a little flavour in the background; it is a structural element in how your character lives on a day-to-day basis, including their loyalty and what they can and cannot offer a romantic partner.

A believable illegal economy in fantasy will typically include the following elements: the logistics of the illegal economy are visible (routes, ports, chokepoints), the illegal economy presents organised crime as an institution (accounting, codes of conduct, and governance), and the illegal economy provides a means by which to produce romantic moments (the secrecy of the illegal economy produces the eroticism of keeping secrets, sharing risks develops trust, and moral ambiguity creates a crucible for the development of love).

How Does Your Underground Economy Work?

If either character operates in a shadow economy, you need to know how it functions. Not every detail, but enough that the criminal world feels like a system rather than a set of isolated crimes.

ELEMENT	WHAT TO DECIDE	WHY IT MATTERS FOR ROMANCE
What's traded?	Contraband, stolen goods, information, magical substances, people, assassinations	The moral weight of what your character sells determines how much redemption the romance needs to carry

ELEMENT	WHAT TO DECIDE	WHY IT MATTERS FOR ROMANCE
Who controls the routes?	Ports, tunnels, inter-world crossings, auction houses, guild halls	Chokepoints are where tension concentrates, and where lovers must rely on each other to survive
How is trust enforced?	Reputation, violence, oaths, magical contracts, codes of conduct	Criminal trust systems double as romantic constraints: “no questions,” “no attachments,” vows that forbid vulnerability
What does failure cost?	Death, exposure, loss of territory, betrayal by allies	The stakes of the criminal life are the stakes of the love story
How does the law interact?	Corrupt officials, selective enforcement, raids, informants	If guards are omniscient when you need a chase and blind when you need a kiss, the world falls apart

In *Six of Crows*, Kaz Brekker doesn’t just run a gang. He runs infrastructure. He dredges a harbour, builds docks, mortgages his gambling house to finance the upgrade, and then captures the inflow of tourists and ship crews by steering them into gang-owned vice venues. Furthermore, he sells shares in the operation to legitimate businessmen, converting lawful investors into stakeholders dependent on criminal stability. It’s a textbook depiction of chokepoint economics: control the entry point, then monetise everything downstream. The romance between Kaz and Inej is built on the same logic as his business: staged disclosure, controlled vulnerability, trust as a calculated risk. Each moment of intimacy for Kaz represents a moment when he surrenders some of his carefully maintained operational security. He wants her on the job. She needs to determine if she’s being regarded as a partner or merely an asset. The romance is inseparable from the economics.

In *A Darker Shade of Magic*, the scarce resource isn’t an object but the ability to cross between parallel worlds. Kell smuggles forbidden items between Londons, and his payment system reveals the economics perfectly: he refuses money (it doesn’t translate across worlds) and instead demands “something that matters, something you don’t want to lose.” When Lila steals from him, she doesn’t just take an object; she jeopardises his entire risk profile. Their romance is a trust negotiation that begins with a betrayal and rebuilds through forced alliance, much like how partnerships develop in real smuggling networks.

Secrecy as Romantic Currency

In underground-economy romances, information is both a commodity and an intimacy marker. The information you have about someone's operation is power. What you choose to reveal is vulnerability. Once one character tells the other their real name, their route, their weakness, that's not just emotional openness. It's an economic concession. They've given the other person something that could destroy them.

Criminal romances often track a specific pattern for this reason: the characters begin by withholding everything (operational security), then slowly and incrementally build trust through revealing small pieces of themselves, then reach a point where one of them reveals something that makes them completely vulnerable (the romantic turning point). In *Six of Crows*, Kaz's gloves-off moments aren't just about physical touch. They're about dropping the armour that keeps his operation (and his heart) secure. In con-artist narratives like *The Mask of Mirrors*, the romance is structurally risky because intimacy is simply another form of identity performance, and the reader can't be certain whether affection is genuine or if it'll ultimately be used as leverage until the mask finally comes off.

The Moral Problem

If you are writing a romance where one or both characters profit from a black market/underground economy, then their romance needs to address this issue. Most commonly, authors fall into the trap of using "moral ambiguity," (or as I call it, "he's so morally grey") stating a character is complex but never giving the reader the chance to see if he will make difficult moral decisions. The most successful romances featuring characters who profit from an underground economy require the lovers to choose which good is worth the cost to them: profit versus protecting the vulnerable, loyalty to crew versus loyalty to partner, violence for safety versus violence for control.

In *The Assassin's Blade*, the protagonist finds herself facing slavery as a business guaranteed to produce profit on a mission with her love interest. The author creates a scenario that requires the moral disgust she feels to collide with the economic rationality of a business model and allows the reader to experience a "one room, two beds" moment in the middle of negotiating slave shipments. The romance does not simply ignore the complicity; it utilises it. Both characters become even more intimate because they both know exactly what they do for a living and neither can pretend the work is clean.

In *Hunt on Dark Waters*, the pirate crew operates under a vow system that replaces state law: join or die, obey or be hunted. The captain's controlled display of power, telekinesis used gently, becomes both threat and seduction. The romance asks whether governance violence can coexist with care. It doesn't answer easily.

What moral choice does the underground economy force on your romance?

"Morally grey" isn't a personality trait — it's a decision in a specific moment. The best criminal romances put the character at a fork where both paths cost something real. What's the fork for your character, and what does their choice reveal about what they value more than profit?

Describe a moral fork your character faces — two options, both costly. What do they choose, what does it cost, and what does it reveal to their partner?

YOUR ANSWER

Does either character operate outside the law?

If a character is involved in criminal activity: What illegal activity? What organisation? What code governs their criminal world? What would their lover lose by association? What moral line would they refuse to cross?

YOUR ANSWER

What is the chokepoint in your criminal world?

Every convincing underground economy has a bottleneck: a port, a tunnel, a border crossing, an auction house, a guild hall. It's where power concentrates and where your characters are most vulnerable. What is it, and who controls it?

How does secrecy shape the romance?

If one character operates outside the law, they're keeping secrets. Map the disclosure arc: what do they withhold, what do they reveal, and when does revealing a secret become the romantic turning point?

Describe how the criminal character's walls come down across three stages (early, middle, turning point): What are they hiding, what do they reveal, and what does each revelation cost them?

YOUR ANSWER

What does the non-criminal partner discover, and how do they react?

If your love interest isn't part of the criminal world, the moment they find out is a make-or-break scene. What specifically do they learn? Are they horrified, fascinated, or both? Does it change what they thought they knew about the person they love?

What would going legitimate cost them?

Some criminal romances end with the characters leaving the life. But leaving has a price: lost allies, lost income, lost identity. If your characters went straight, what would they lose?

If your criminal character went legitimate, what would they lose and what would they gain?

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check

QUESTION	ANSWER	EXAMPLE (WEALTH-GAP ROMANCE)
How does government control or affect the economy?		<i>Entailment laws keep estates intact; the Crown grants trade monopolies; taxes fund wars that enrich some and bankrupt others</i>
How do cultural values affect economic behavior?		<i>“Gentlemen don’t work” means heirs can’t earn; merchants are wealthy but not accepted; marrying for money is expected but admitting it is gauche</i>
Could magic solve your characters’ economic problems? Why don’t they use it?		<i>Transmutation is possible but illegal (counterfeiting); money spells are traceable; magical labour is regulated by guild</i>
How does economics interact with your political obstacles?		<i>He needs to marry an heiress to save the estate; she has money but not status. His family</i>

QUESTION	ANSWER	EXAMPLE (WEALTH-GAP ROMANCE)
		<i>opposes her, but needs her dowry</i>

Quick Reference: Economic Stakes

ELEMENT	YOUR WORLD	EXAMPLE (WEALTH-GAP ROMANCE)
Type of economy		<i>Feudal with emerging merchant class — old money (land) vs. new money (trade)</i>
Primary economic obstacle for romance		<i>She's a servant; he's heir to the estate. Their stations make marriage unthinkable.</i>
Economic power imbalance		<i>He could fire her, evict her family, ruin her completely — she has no leverage</i>
The valuable/scarce resource		<i>Land — the estate represents generations of wealth and power</i>
Who controls it		<i>His father, who will disinherit him if he marries beneath his station</i>
Economic debt or obligation		<i>Her family owes debt to his; she works it off. He could forgive it — would that be rescue or control?</i>
Economic sacrifice required to be together		<i>He gives up his inheritance; they start with nothing but each other</i>

Final Thought: Money Gets Personal

The question isn't "how does the tax system work?" It's "what would this character do if they couldn't eat tomorrow?"

Economics creates stakes when it forces impossible choices: love or survival? Pride or security?

Build an economy that makes these choices real.